

STAGE FOURTEEN • PROJECT MANAGEMENT

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Fourteen • Project Management

PURPOSE

Stage Fourteen runs across three sessions — Project Planning Foundations, Managing Execution, and Modern Methodologies & Closing Out — each gets one icebreaker below, built directly from that session's actual content.

This stage can feel abstract or purely procedural if introduced through definitions alone. Each opener instead starts from a genuinely familiar, non-technical experience — planning a party, a frustrating project update, choosing between a fixed plan and a flexible one — so the formal vocabulary that follows lands as naming something participants already understand intuitively.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Three Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

The Napkin Project Plan

TIME: 10 min

1. Ask each participant to think of a genuinely simple real-life project (planning a birthday party, moving apartments, organizing a trip) and, without any formal training, sketch on paper what they'd naturally do first, second, third.
2. In pairs, compare sketches: did either of you naturally include something like a scope, a timeline, or a risk check, without knowing the formal term for it?
3. Quick full-group tally: how many people's natural instincts already touched on something this stage will formally name?

WHY THIS WORKS

This surfaces, before any formal teaching, that people already have real planning instincts — project management vocabulary formalizes and sharpens something participants are already doing informally, which is exactly the framing FIRST R1 needs to land well.

SESSION 2

The Silent Status Update

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask the group: think of a project you were involved in where you genuinely had no idea how it was actually going until something went wrong.
2. Quick round-robin: one sentence each on what that felt like, and what would have told you sooner.
3. Facilitator collects the “what would have told you sooner” answers visibly — they'll map almost exactly onto this session's status report and communication plan content.

WHY THIS WORKS

This produces, in the group's own words, the actual case for status reports and stakeholder communication before the session formally introduces either — the upcoming FIRSTS land as solutions to a frustration the group just named themselves.

SESSION 3

Agile or Not?

TIME: 8 min

1. Read the group a few short, real-life scenarios (a wedding planned a year in advance vs. a food truck's daily menu vs. a home renovation with a fixed budget) and ask them to vote: does this feel more like a fixed, sequential plan, or a flexible, iterative one?
2. Briefly discuss the split votes — where did people disagree, and why?
3. No need to resolve it definitively; just surface that the right approach genuinely depends on the nature of the work.

WHY THIS WORKS

This previews, through familiar, non-technical examples, the actual decision logic behind choosing Agile, Scrum, or Kanban — letting the group discover the distinction themselves before the formal frameworks are introduced.